rana never did seriously entertain the idea of submission to the Mughals, for he had done much to strengthen defences in the territories he controlled. He guarded his southern border rigorously, improved fortifications in the Aravalli ranges, and ensured amicable relations with the local Bhil tribes. He also induced the farmers of the fertile plains around Chittor and Mandalgarh to relocate, leaving the plains barren and desolate: the farmers were told to settle in inaccessible hilly areas. He ensured his orders were carried out with ‘unrelenting severity’, according to James Tod. It was said that when a poor goatherd dared to bring his animals to pasture in the plains, he was killed, and his body hung up to serve as a warning to others. According to folklore, Rana Pratap took vows of austerity, to use no gold and silver dishes, nor sleep in soft beds, until Chittor was won.

In 1576, having subdued some especially resistant opponents like the mirzas and the Afghans, Akbar finally decided to send an army against the rana in his stronghold at Gogunda. Appointing the young Man Singh to head the Mughal army against Rana Pratap was a perfectly poised balancing act. Akbar not only demonstrated his complete confidence in his Kachhwaha relatives but gambled wisely that his Rajput troops, who may have fought with less than total ardour against a greatly respected Rajput foe, would now be galvanized by a Kachhwaha chieftain. Akbar was also rewarding Man Singh’s personal qualities of courage, able generalship, and resourcefulness. Along with Man Singh, Akbar also appointed some reputed Mughal generals, such as Asaf Khan, the mir bakshi, Ghazi Khan Badakshi, and Shah Ghazi Khan, to lead the army. That not all the Mughal courtiers shared Akbar’s foresight and meritocratic pragmatism can be seen in the reaction of one Naqib Khan, when Badauni begged him to have him enrolled in the army. ‘If a Hindu had not been the leader of the army,’ Naqib Khan assured Badauni, trying to dissuade him, ‘I should myself have been the first to have asked permission to join it.’ The presence of the cerebral Badauni among the Mughal troops was itself surprising. Badauni had not exactly covered himself with glory up to this point and may have been trying to redeem himself as he was still in 1576 eager to rise in the Padshah’s court. He had been sullen about his mansab of 20, had been unable to carry out his branding duties, and had requested a jagir of land in lieu of a military rank. Akbar at this stage of his rule, was quite rigid about mansabdars maintaining the actual number of cavalrymen assigned to them according to their rank. Badauni would have been obliged to produce the 20